

sides, people are shutting their eyes to the flip side of the coin. If investigations are carried out properly and the right persons punished, such a situation would not have occurred. I accept that Muslims too need to introspect why they are always held responsible for anti-national activities. But the Government must be careful before alleging that Muslims will mostly be behind all terrorist activities.

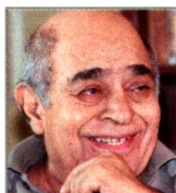
In Malegaon, since Muslims are in a majority, the Hindu community finds itself on the margins of society. I remember visiting our Hindu neighbours and friends, collaborating with them for work and celebrating our festivals together in the past. Now things have changed. Even if the trend continues, it is only out of courtesy. Several Hindus in my city have sold their lands and moved to locations where the entire community can stay together. In the rest of the country, where Muslims are in minority, they are moving away in a similar fashion to save their lives and keep their

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dignity intact. In 1992, the world witnessed Babri Masjid being brought down on the basis of sheer muscle power. This made Muslims feel they were being pushed to the margins with brute force.

In 20 to 25 years from now, I see the Hindu community standing at the same crossroad as the Muslims are today. The reason: the world moves in a cyclic progression. We will reap what we sow. And the seeds of hatred that have been sown will come back to us in some time. If we tread on the wrong path today, the repercussions will be for all to see—across communities.

As told to Swati Mathur



WARIS ALVI

Urdu scholar based in Ahmedabad

Pakistan is behind the radicalisation of this small number that has taken to terrorism in India, whose composite culture will still prevail

Muslims are under siege”. “They are becoming targets of Islam-phobia”. “India is a victim of Islamic terrorism”. These are oft-repeated statements being made in many quarters and also find expression in the media. To me, most of these thoughts are in the realm of belief more than reality. These are sweeping statements which simply can’t be made on the basis of what a few individuals or even groups say. Such conclusions can be drawn only after a deep study covering the common Muslims across a broad spectrum.

The reality is that a large number of common Muslims are largely unaffected by the terrorism in the country and its aftermath. They continue to do their daily chores and even prosper, almost unaffected. Yes, when a bomb blast takes place or police launches a drive to locate Muslims in-

involved in it, there is momentary fear or even anger but it is just a temporary phase.

Despite provocations of Hindu communal organisations, there is still little ground for Muslims to feel that their Indianness is being questioned. You have to meet the common Hindus and Muslims tied by bonds of business, culture and other features to know the real picture. For example, in Ahmedabad, which saw severe anti-Muslim riots during the dark 2002 Gujarat episode, Hindus continue to buy clothes from the Dhalgarwad area where most traders are Muslims. In Gujarat’s famous kite-festival, most kite-makers are Muslims and kite-fliers are Hindus. In the economic field, Muslims continue to progress. They are now in a very big way into the shoe and cloth business. On the other hand, one can easily see topi-clad